

Meridian State University

Academic Integrity Policy

Standards, Violations, Reporting, and Sanctions

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Issuing Office: Office of the Registrar & Academic Affairs

Review Cycle: Annual

1. Statement of Principle

Meridian State University is committed to fostering a culture of intellectual honesty in which all members of the academic community — students, faculty, and staff — take individual responsibility for the integrity of their work. Academic integrity is foundational to the value of the degrees the University confers and to the trust placed in its scholarship.

2. Definitions of Academic Misconduct

2.1 Plagiarism

The representation of another person's words, ideas, data, or creative work as one's own without proper attribution, whether intentional or resulting from careless citation practice.

2.2 Cheating

Using or attempting to use unauthorized materials, information, or assistance in any academic exercise, including but not limited to unauthorized collaboration, use of prohibited devices during examinations, and possession of unauthorized notes.

2.3 Fabrication and Falsification

The invention or alteration of data, citations, or results in a laboratory report, research paper, or clinical record.

2.4 Unauthorized Use of Artificial Intelligence Tools

Submitting work generated substantially by an AI tool as one's own without disclosure, where the course syllabus or assignment instructions prohibit or restrict such use, constitutes a violation under this policy in the same manner as unattributed use of any other outside source.

2.5 Facilitating Academic Dishonesty

Knowingly helping another student violate this policy, including sharing exam questions, completing coursework on another's behalf, or impersonating another student in an exam setting.

3. Reporting Process

Faculty who suspect a violation must document the evidence and submit an Academic Integrity Incident Report to the Office of Academic Integrity within 10 business days of discovery. Students are notified in writing and given the opportunity to respond within 5 business days before any finding is made.

- First-time, lower-severity violations may be resolved through a Faculty-Student Resolution Agreement.
- Repeat or severe violations are referred to the Academic Integrity Board for a formal hearing.
- Students may be accompanied by an advisor of their choosing throughout the process, though the advisor may not speak on the student's behalf during hearings.

4. Sanctions

Severity Level	Example	Typical Sanction Range
Level 1 — Minor	Improper citation, unintentional paraphrasing, missing	Warning; assignment resubmission
Level 2 — Moderate	Unauthorized collaboration, crib sheet in exam	Zero on assignment; grade reduction
Level 3 — Serious	Fabricated data, purchased essay, exam impersonation	Course failure; disciplinary probation
Level 4 — Severe / Repeat	Second offense, organized cheating ring	Suspension or dismissal

Sanctions are recorded in the student's confidential integrity file, maintained separately from the academic transcript except where suspension or dismissal is imposed.

5. Appeals

A student found responsible for a violation by the Academic Integrity Board may appeal to the Vice Provost for Academic Affairs within 10 business days of the decision, on the grounds of procedural error, new evidence, or disproportionate sanction. The Vice Provost's decision is final.

6. Roles of the Academic Integrity Board

The Academic Integrity Board is a standing body composed of five faculty members and two student representatives, each serving staggered two-year terms and trained annually on hearing procedures and unconscious bias. A quorum of four members, including at least one student representative, is required to conduct a hearing.

The Board's role is limited to determining, by a preponderance of the evidence, whether a violation occurred and, if so, recommending an appropriate sanction from the ranges described in Section 5. The Board does not have authority to impose sanctions exceeding the ranges published in this policy without written concurrence from the Vice Provost for Academic Affairs.

7. Faculty Responsibilities

Instructors are expected to clearly state academic integrity expectations, including any course-specific policy on permitted collaboration or AI tool use, in their syllabi. Faculty should design assessments that reasonably deter misconduct and must report all suspected violations rather than resolving them unilaterally with an undisclosed grade penalty.

8. Frequently Asked Questions

Does a first offense always appear on my transcript?

No. Level 1 and most Level 2 sanctions are recorded only in the confidential integrity file. Transcript notation applies only where suspension or dismissal is imposed.

Can I use generative AI tools for brainstorming even if a syllabus is silent on the topic?

Where a syllabus does not address AI tool use, students should confirm permitted use directly with the instructor before relying on such tools, as silence should not be interpreted as blanket permission.

Is a hearing decision by the Academic Integrity Board immediately final?

No. Students retain the right to appeal to the Vice Provost for Academic Affairs within 10 business days, as described in Section 6 of this policy.

9. Related Policies and Resources

This policy should be read in conjunction with other governing University policies, including the University Catalog, the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) Notice, and any college- or department-specific handbooks that supplement, but do not contradict, the standards set out here. Where a conflict exists between this policy and a college-level document, this policy governs unless an explicit written exception has been approved by the Provost's Office.

- University Catalog (undergraduate and graduate editions), published annually
- FERPA Notice of Student Rights, available through the Office of the Registrar
- Student Handbook, distributed at orientation and available online
- College- and department-specific supplemental guidelines, where applicable

10. Contact and Further Assistance

Questions regarding the interpretation or application of this policy should be directed to the Office of Academic Integrity. Students are encouraged to reach out early in the process, as many concerns can be resolved informally before they require a formal procedure.

Contact Point	Detail
Office	Office of Academic Integrity
Email	integrity@meridianstate.edu
Phone	(555) 201-4430
Office Hours	Monday–Friday, 8:30 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.
Walk-in Location	Student Services Building, Suite 200

11. Policy Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
1.0	August 2021	Initial policy adopted by the Board of Trustees.
1.1	August 2023	Clarified procedural timelines and appeal deadlines.
2.0	August 2025	Comprehensive revision to align with updated accreditation standards.

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
2.1	August 2026	Minor updates for the current academic year; see effective date above.

Note: This document supersedes all prior versions upon its effective date. Archived versions are available upon request from the issuing office.